Tuni. Ajay Goyal (many of whose photographs appear in this book) expressed his keenness to accompany Kiran to Tuni, and she certainly did not mind. In Tuni she had the *patwaris* (revenue-collecting officials) organize the uprooting of the poppy plants from the fields and Ajay took a beautiful picture of her standing in one of the fields with a bouquet of poppy flowers in her hands.

She had to get back to Delhi urgently because she had to appear before the Justice D. P. Wadhwa Commission (enquiring into the lawyers' strike and its aftermath; for details see Chapter 11) and so left earlier than the rest of the NCB team. A few days later the dailies splashed her 'poppy field' picture on their pages along with the Tuni story. The story, of course, was reported from Dehradun. The NCB officials' hackles went up. Their only question was: Had she come back to Delhi earlier than the others so that she could hog the limelight? Anyway, from that day onwards, she was never given any operational assignment throughout her stint at the NCB.

As a matter of fact, she was never ever sent out on any foreign training assignment either, whereas every year at a conference at least two or three such opportunities would arise. Once, a file was put up to Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi for sending an officer to Kuala Lumpur, Malaysia, to address, and participate in, a world conference on the drug abuse problem in schools. Rajiv Gandhi was quite aware of the work she had done in this field, especially after the setting up of the Navjyoti centre. Therefore, he wrote 'Why not Kiran?' on the file. That was the reason why she was informed by the PM's Office, just two days before the conference, that she was being sent to Malaysia.

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Besides being dubbed a 'publicity hound', Kiran has also been branded as a controversial officer. Is her being controversial a mere myth or is there something about her and her mode of functioning that lends credibility to such an accusation? One of her first acts that was viewed in this light was her arrest of a sitting MP's (J. S. Baraia's) private secretary, A. P. Karunakaran. He was held on charges of possessing a diamond ring suspected to have been stolen during an armed dacoity in Delhi in December 1980. In this context, a dreaded criminal revealed that he had been harboured by the abovementioned private secretary who even sported a ring that had been given to him from the loot of that particular dacoity. Kiran and her officer in charge, special staff, Gian Chand, then kept watch over the secretary's residence. They covered themselves up in crude blankets and moved around the premises, as if they were watchmen, in the dark, late one night. As the opportunity presented itself the person was arrested and sure enough he was wearing the ring given to him as informed. The news of his arrest was widely reported in various newspapers on 24 and 25 April 1981.

Delhi's Commissioner of Police P. S. Bhinder took umbrage at this arrest and ticked her off in no uncertain terms. Did she not know, he asked her, that the arrested person was a sitting MP's private secretary? How dare she take the initiative into her own hands? he demanded. She should have consulted him first and sought his permission before taking any action. Even at that early stage in her career she stood by her decision and left the onus of taking any action against her upon the police chief himself.

Her act of leaving Mizoram in the dead of night was also made controversial. (See Chapters 12 and 13 for details.) Kiran had been threatened by the state minister of law that if she did not surrender her daughter's medical seat in writing, then there was the possibility of the agitating youth surrounding her house and the Mizoram State Government would not take the responsibility for the consequences. In a place far away from home, all alone, with threats to her life and no assurance of any protection from the state machinery, she had no option but to fend for herself. Consequently, she drove to the governor's residence and informed him of her decision based on the exigencies of the